obscuring the beginnings of the Shansabanis' coalescence as an imperial lineage.[16] Expectedly, then, an overall socio-cultural apprehension of historical Ghur, parallel with the eastern and western reaches of Afghanistan described elsewhere in this volume, still has not come into view. While the tracts from Kabul westward until Bamiyan and its valleys are better known thanks to the abundance of Buddhist monastic establishments and their attraction for pilgrims from afar who were prolific travel writers,[17] Ghur itself has resisted such knowledge economies, its mountainous terrain and the supposed insularity of its inhabitants making methodical exploration more perilous and reportage less frequent.[18]

Despite the challenges – and perhaps *because* of them – a piecing together of the region's historical, cultural, and religious traces should be attempted. The varying degrees of artificiality in determining the political boundaries of nation-states in the twentieth century have already been subjected to rigorous analysis. Such a perspective is equally necessary for the domestic parceling *within* nations of provinces and states, which are frequently delineated for ease of administration – including gathering of census data, taxation, and revenue collection – rather than strictly adhering to the historic extents of linguistic and cultural geographies. Static administrative boundaries of modern times call for deconstruction all the more when treating a landscape largely determined by the varying degrees and types of transhumance and/or nomadic pastoralism among its populations. In addition to sparse references in texts, information from archaeological surveys/excavations and also modern observations can be useful in better imagining the extent and geography of historical Ghur. Lastly, we must bear in mind that the conceptualization of Ghur during the tenth through mid-twelfth centuries not only differs from the political maps of today, it has varied through time as well, depending on the shifting bases of power of prominent chieftains in the region.

Ahmad Ali Kohzad,[19] among Ghur's most thorough explorers in the mid-twentieth century, described the region as "a fortress surrounded by yet other mountains … which has no doors, or if there be any, are narrow valleys difficult of access." However, such a description should not render Ghur impenetrable, given the region's many (principally non-sedentist?) inhabitants, both in the past and in the present (Figures 2.11 and 2.12). The eminent Afghanistan scholar Louis Dupree's observations are also worth recalling: the mountains "never truly served as barriers to cultural, economic, or political penetration, but merely funneled peoples and ideas along certain routes."[20] The northern reaches of Ghur, then, were hemmed by mountains (primarily the foothills of the Hindu Kush), which, rather than preventing movement, diverted it to the seasonally passable routes of access to Ghur's valleys. The region's southern reaches bordered the dry and flat plains of Zamindawar and Sistan (map, p. xvi).[21]

A constant of Ghur's landscape would have been its major northern